



Chapter 5

User personas

Ages 15-18 · the threshold

Almost adults now. Identity comes out, the career-or-marriage fork appears, relationships and rights get real, and the future presses hard. The register grows up here: this is the bridge to the adult chapters. India-segmented personas so Chapter 5 graduates with the player.

Almost adults. Treat them like it.

Chapter 5 is the threshold. Some players turn eighteen inside it: legal adults, voters, at the age of consent. Identity stops being a question and starts being an answer. The fork appears, college or a wedding, a career or a "good match". Relationships, sex and rights are real or about to be. And the future presses down with an exam system that, in India, can feel like the whole of life. Anything that talks down to them now is gone. The product has to graduate.

Four shifts from Chapter 4

SHIFT	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT THE DESIGN MUST DO
Identity comes out	Orientation and gender identity are lived now, often without a safe place to be.	Affirm and protect; acceptance is the protective factor.
The fork in the road	College or marriage, career or "settle down", especially for girls.	Back agency over the future; counter the timeline.
Adult stakes	Real relationships, real consent, real rights as they reach eighteen.	Straight answers on consent, health and the law.
The future presses	Board and entrance exams, comparison, launch anxiety, real distress.	Life-readiness and mental health, with real routes to help.

Eight personas, three Indian segments, three roles. Each ends in design implications for the nine Chapter 5 games: My Choices My Future, Status Know It, Mutual, Spectrum, Lead the Way, Change Makers, Justice League, Life Ready, and Decoded.

At the edge of the nest.

The home segments carry through to the launch point: a parent learning to accept a son, a parent weighing a daughter's future, a parent reaching for a son's first shot at college, and the staff trying to get them all out safely.

PERSONA	ROLE	SEGMENT	IN ONE LINE	THE LEVER FOR DEPTH
Anjali Sharma, 48	Parent	Metro	Her son came out; she loves him and is terrified.	Acceptance is the protective factor.
Lata Deshpande, 44	Parent	Tier-2	After 12th: a college seat, or a wedding?	Back her future; ease the family's fear.
Ramesh Kumar, 46	Parent	Low-income	His son could be the first to reach college.	Decode an opaque system; access.
Arjun, 17	Teen	Metro	Out at home, careful at school, alone online.	Affirm, protect, connect.
Sneha, 17	Teen	Tier-2	Topped the boards; the relatives brought proposals.	Agency over her own timeline.
Vijay, 17	Teen	Low-income	Bright, broke, the system is a maze.	Rights, information, real allies.
Mr. Reddy, 50	Educator	Career counsellor	Watching the exam crisis up close.	Launch-ready: futures and minds.
Tara, 29	Educator	NGO youth helpline	The call kids make when home isn't safe.	Safe space, referral, near-peer.

THE PARENT WHO'S LEARNING

Anjali Sharma, 48

Teacher · Delhi · son Arjun, 17 · loves him, fears for him

"He told me he's gay. I said I love him, and I meant it. Then I lay awake all night, scared of everything the world will do to him."

HOME	Nuclear; husband less accepting; extended family conservative.
LANGUAGES	Hindi / English; the family reads the room more than the words.
DEVICES	Arjun has full digital autonomy; she would never search his phone.
CARE	Class 12; co-ed school where he stays carefully invisible.
MONEY	Comfortable; the fear is social, not financial.

Since he told her. Anjali's love was instant; her confidence was not. She does not know how to handle her husband's silence, the relatives' questions, or her own conditioning that keeps whispering "is it a phase?". She has read that a parent's acceptance is the single biggest thing protecting a queer teen, and she desperately wants to be that, she just does not know how, or where to learn without exposing Arjun.

What she wants

- To get acceptance right, for Arjun's safety and her own peace.
- Words and facts to counter "phase", "choice" and the relatives.
- To understand the world Arjun is navigating, and its real risks.
- Somewhere to learn privately, without outing her son.

The bias she's unlearning

Inherited, not chosen, and already loosening. The quiet scripts that say this is a phase, a Western import, or something to fix.

It's just a phase.**Acceptance will encourage it.**

She is the highest-leverage person in Arjun's life. Equip her, and his odds change.

Why she'd bounce

- Anything that frames her uncertainty as bigotry; she's trying.
- Content that ignores the Indian family reality she has to manage.
- Material she could not open without the household seeing.

PUSHES ANJALI AWAY

Content that scolds her for not being a perfect ally on day one. She shuts it, ashamed.

MAGIC TO ANJALI

A calm, private guide that meets her where she is, gives her the facts and the words, and shows her exactly how to keep Arjun safe and loved.

Design implications

- 1 Build a parent path for acceptance: meet uncertainty with patience, not judgement.
- 2 Arm her with the evidence (acceptance protects) and the words to face relatives.
- 3 Ground it in the Indian family reality; private to open, never outing the child.
- 4 Make affirming the child the clear, concrete, doable next step.

AT THE FORK

Lata Deshpande, 44

Anganwadi supervisor · Kolhapur · daughter Sneha, 17 (Class 12)

"She scored brilliantly. I'm proud. But the proposals have started, and the relatives ask why a girl needs to go so far to study."

HOME	Husband, Sneha (17), a younger son; opinionated extended family.
LANGUAGES	Marathi at home; Sneha is fluent in English too.
DEVICES	Sneha has a phone; trust is higher than in Chapter 4, but watched.
CARE	Class 12; entrance exams; a city college would mean leaving home.
MONEY	Modest; can stretch for education if convinced it's worth it.

Results week. Sneha wants a city college and a career; the relatives want a wedding while "a good boy is available". Lata is genuinely torn: she believes in her daughter and she fears the gossip, the cost, and a girl living alone in a strange city. She is not the villain of this story; she is the swing vote. Give her confidence and a plan, and she will fight for Sneha's future.

What she wants

- The best, safest future for Sneha, free of a decision she'll regret.
- Reassurance that a girl studying away can be safe and supported.
- Practical paths: scholarships, hostels, careers, costs, safety.
- A way to hold off the relatives without a family rupture.

The bias in the room

A daughter's future as negotiable, marriage as the safe default, education as fine until a match appears.

Why study so far, she'll marry anyway.

A good match won't wait.

Lata wins when ambition comes with a credible safety plan she can defend.

Why she'd bounce

- Content that paints marriage or the family as the enemy.
- Abstract "follow your dreams" with no concrete, safe plan.
- Anything the relatives could call "putting ideas in her head".

NOT ENOUGH FOR LATA

A slogan about empowerment. It does not answer "but is she safe, and how do we afford it?".

MAGIC TO LATA

A clear picture of Sneha's options, safety and support, plus the words to buy her a few more years and a real future.

Design implications

- 1 Pair aspiration with a concrete, safe plan: scholarships, hostels, careers, costs.
- 2 Name the timeline pressure with empathy, never by attacking the family.
- 3 Speak to a girl's safety and autonomy together, not as a trade-off.
- 4 Give the parent language to hold off the proposals respectfully.

REACHING FOR A FIRST

Ramesh Kumar, 46

Factory worker · peri-urban Tamil Nadu · son Vijay, 17 (Class 12, government school)

"He could be the first in our family to go to college. I just don't understand any of it, the forms, the exams, the scholarships. I'm afraid of failing him."

HOME	Two rooms; Ramesh, his wife, Vijay and a daughter.
LANGUAGES	Tamil; limited English; Ramesh left school early.
DEVICES	One shared smartphone; data managed carefully.
CARE	Government school; no career guidance; entrances are a mystery.
MONEY	Every option weighed against "he could be earning instead".

The crossroads. Vijay is bright and on the edge of something no one in the family has reached. But the path is invisible: entrance exams, application deadlines, scholarships, reservation, hostels, none of it explained to people like Ramesh. The default pull is "start earning, help the family now". Ramesh wants more for his son; he simply has no map, and the clock is running.

What he wants

- To not let his son's one shot slip through ignorance.
- A plain-language map of exams, deadlines, scholarships and aid.
- Confidence that the investment is real and reachable.
- Something he and Vijay can use in their language, offline.

Why he'd bounce

- English, jargon-heavy "guidance" written for the already-informed.
- Online-only tools that assume devices and data he doesn't have.
- Anything that makes him feel stupid for not knowing.

USELESS TO RAMESH

A glossy careers portal in English. It assumes the very knowledge he's missing.

The bias he's up against

Higher education as not-for-us, a poor boy's place as the workforce, ambition as risky overreach.

College isn't for people like us.

Better he earns now.

Ramesh isn't unwilling; he's uninformed. A clear map changes the decision.

MAGIC TO RAMESH

An offline, spoken, Tamil walk-through of exactly what Vijay must do, by when, and what help exists to pay for it.

Design implications

- 1 Decode the system: a plain, offline, in-language map of exams, deadlines, scholarships and aid.
- 2 Frame study as a real, reachable investment, not a gamble for "people like us".
- 3 Never condescend; assume zero prior knowledge without making him feel it.
- 4 Connect to real access programmes and mentors, not just information.

THE LEARNER

Arjun, 17

Metro · gay, recently out at home · "free in one room, careful everywhere else"

"At home it's getting better. At school I'm invisible on purpose. Online I found people like me, and also a lot I had to learn to dodge."

Where he is, developmentally

- A whole, ordinary 17-year-old, who also happens to be gay and newly out.
- Late adolescence: identity consolidating, first crushes, big feelings.
- Carries minority stress: vigilance, hiding at school, fear of slips.
- Finds community and information online, good, and risky, mixed together.
- Needs accurate health and relationship facts free of the stigma piled on him.

What he's navigating. Arjun is not a problem to be managed; he is a teen who needs the same things every teen needs, plus a world that is safe to be himself in. He has heard plenty about what he is "supposed" to be ashamed of. What he rarely gets is matter-of-fact, affirming information about relationships, consent and health, and the simple message that he is normal and has rights.

ALIENATING TO ARJUN

Content that treats relationships as only straight, or treats him as a risk or a special case.

MAGIC TO ARJUN

An app that just includes him: consent, health and relationships that assume he exists, plus community and his rights, without shame.

Design implications

- 1 Be inclusive by default: relationships and consent that assume queer teens exist, not a bolt-on.
- 2 Give accurate, stigma-free health information (incl. status and testing) framed for everyone.
- 3 Affirm identity and name his rights (377 read down, NALSA); normal, and legal.
- 4 Connect to safe community and help; private throughout, never outing him.

THE LEARNER

Sneha, 17

Tier-2 · Class 12 topper at the fork · "a future she can see and almost reach"

"I worked for years for these marks. Now everyone's talking about a wedding, and I'm supposed to be grateful."

Where she is, developmentally

- High-achieving, articulate, ready to lead; quietly furious at the double standard.
- Weighing college, career and a first relationship against family expectation.
- Anxious about the future and about disappointing people she loves.
- Finding her voice; capable of real leadership if it's encouraged.
- Needs straight talk on consent, worth and choices as she steps into adult life.

Her moment. Sneha is at the exact point where a life either opens or narrows. She has the ability and the ambition; what she lacks is backing, a plan, and permission to want more. She does not need to be told to dream; she needs the tools to make the case, the confidence to lead, and honest guidance on the relationships and decisions now in front of her.

HOLLOW TO SNEHA

A motivational poster about "girl power". It doesn't help her win the actual argument at home.

MAGIC TO SNEHA

Real tools to plan her future, lead, and make her case, plus honest talk on relationships and her own worth.

Design implications

- 1 Back agency: help her plan a future and argue for it, not just feel inspired.
- 2 Build leadership and voice; let her be a change-maker without burning out or performing.
- 3 Give grown-up guidance on consent, relationships and worth as she nears adulthood.
- 4 Tie ambition to life-readiness: money, decisions, leaving home.

THE LEARNER

Vijay, 17

Low-income · first-gen aspirant · "all the talent, none of the map"

"Nobody in my family has done this. I'm guessing my way through forms and deadlines, and terrified of missing one."

Where he is

- Bright and driven; school is his ladder and he knows it.
- Facing entrance exams and applications with no one to guide him.
- Reads English slowly; sharp and motivated in his home language.
- About to step into adult systems, work, money, rights, with no preparation.
- His mentors are a teacher and an NGO worker, not his overstretched parents.

OUT OF REACH FOR VIJAY

An English, online, assumes-you-know-the-game resource. It is built for the already-advantaged.

What he's up against. Vijay's barrier is not ability; it is information and access. He is the student who makes it when someone hands him the map, the deadlines, the scholarships, the rights, and falls through when no one does. As he nears eighteen he also needs the basics of adult life, contracts, money, harassment law, that his peers with connected families simply absorb.

MAGIC TO VIJAY

An offline, in-language guide to the path and to adult life, deadlines, scholarships, rights, money, that levels the field.

Design implications

- 1 Decode adult systems: applications, scholarships, money, contracts, in plain language.
- 2 Teach rights for the launch: harassment law, fair work, where to get help.
- 3 Offline and in-language; usable on a shared phone, in stolen time.
- 4 Route to real mentors and access programmes, not just facts.

CAREER COUNSELLOR

Mr. Reddy, 50

Class 11-12 teacher and career counsellor · watching the launch, and the pressure

"They carry the weight of one exam as if it's the whole of their lives. Some of them are breaking under it, and I have ten minutes per child."

His reality

- Guides hundreds of students through boards, entrances and the future.
- Sees real exam-stress distress, and the marriage-versus-college pull on girls.
- Knows most leave school unprepared for adult life and rights.
- Stretched thin; wants tools that scale his limited time.

USELESS TO HIM

Generic "study tips". His students' problem isn't studying; it's pressure, choices and what comes next.

What he needs from SwipeEd. Something that helps students think about choices, futures and life-readiness beyond the exam, plus mental-health content that takes the pressure seriously and points to real help. A credible resource he can assign that does the career-and-life guidance the system never gives him time for, and that flags the student who is quietly drowning.

MAGIC TO MR. REDDY

A guide to choices, life-readiness and coping he can assign at scale, with serious mental-health framing and a path to help.

Design implications

- 1 Carry real career and life-readiness guidance the system has no time to deliver.
- 2 Take exam pressure seriously: coping, perspective, and clear routes to help.
- 3 Make it assignable and self-paced, to scale one counsellor across many students.
- 4 Help him spot and gently refer a student in real distress.

YOUTH WORKER

Tara, 29

NGO youth helpline and safe-space worker · the adult kids reach when home can't be

"The ones who call me have nowhere else. A boy whose family found out. A girl about to be pulled from school. They need a safe voice, fast."

Her reality

- Runs a youth helpline and safe spaces for vulnerable 15-18s.
- Supports queer youth, first-gen students, kids facing rejection or marriage.
- Trusted because she is near-peer, confidential and non-judgmental.
- Works multilingual, low-resource, and is the last line before crisis.

WRONG FOR HER KIDS

Stiff, authoritative, one-size content. It breaks trust with teens who are already let down by authority.

What she needs from SwipeEd. Affirming, accurate, multilingual content she can point a vulnerable teen to between calls: identity, rights, safety, mental health, and clear referral to real help. A tool that matches her warm, non-judgmental voice and reaches kids before they hit crisis, especially those whose own families cannot, yet, be their safe place.

MAGIC TO TARA

A warm, affirming, multilingual companion she can hand a frightened teen, with real referral and rights built in.

Design implications

- 1 Voice it as a warm, non-judgmental near-peer, the brand's adult register, kind.
- 2 Centre safety, identity, rights and mental health for the most vulnerable.
- 3 Build in clear, real referral to helplines, safe spaces and trusted adults.
- 4 Multilingual and private; reach kids before crisis, and when home isn't safe.

What Chapter 5 must do differently.

Across all eight personas, one demand dominates: treat them as the near-adults they are, and hand them, honestly, the things they will need the day after they leave: an identity, a plan, their rights, and somewhere to turn.

PRINCIPLE	BECAUSE	SHOWS UP AS
Treat them as near-adults	Some are eighteen inside this chapter; condescension is fatal.	Straight answers, the brand's adult voice, no infantilising.
Affirm identity, safely	Orientation and gender are lived now, often with no safe place.	Inclusive by default; acceptance as protection; rights named.
Back agency at the fork	College or marriage, career or "settle down", decides a life.	Plans, not slogans; counter the timeline; safety plus ambition.
Adult stakes, handled straight	Consent, health and the law are real as they reach eighteen.	Mutual consent, status and testing, rights, framed for India.
Life-ready and steady	Money, decisions, leaving home, and an exam system that crushes.	Adulting skills, coping, and serious routes to mental-health help.
Voice and leadership	This is when teens become change-makers, or get talked over.	Leadership and allyship without burnout or performance.
Decode adult systems	First-gen and low-income teens face an invisible maze.	Plain, offline, in-language maps of exams, scholarships, work, rights.
Be the safe adult	For many, home cannot yet be the safe place.	Affirming, confidential, near-peer; real referral built in.

The same principles, on the nine Chapter 5 games

GAME	THE DEPTH MOVE FROM THESE PERSONAS
My Choices, My Future (g29)	Agency at the fork: Sneha's college-vs-marriage, Vijay's path; no single timeline.
Status: Know It (g30)	Testing and status without stigma; framed for everyone, never aimed at Arjun.
Mutual (g31)	Mutual consent and communication for real relationships, inclusive, India age-of-consent aware.
Spectrum (g32)	Arjun's core game: orientation and gender identity, affirming, with 377 and NALSA named.
Lead the Way (g33)	Sneha's voice: leadership beyond "a man's role"; the double standard refused.
Change Makers (g34)	Activism and allyship without burnout or performance; small, real action.
Justice League (g35)	Rights for the launch: consent, harassment and POSH, work, digital, where to get help.
Life Ready (g42)	Adulting and resilience: money, decisions, leaving home, and the exam-pressure mind.

Decoded (g36)

Media literacy for adult life: deepfakes, AI, data and privacy as they enter work.

Next: Chapters 6-8 flip to the adult, dark register (college, building a life, parenthood), or a Chapter 5 game-by-game redesign built on this brief.